



U3

What is U3?

U3 is a new hardware and software platform that enables personal workspace portability by allowing USB Flash drives to carry, store, and use one's own applications and data on any PC.

Who developed it?

U3 is the result of a collaboration between SanDisk and M-Systems Flash Disk Pioneers Ltd.

Where is it used?

U3 is used to develop what are being called 'U3 smart drives' and applications compatible with them. These drives are targeted at just about anybody who wants to carry data and applications wherever they go.

When will U3 Smart Drives be available?

Very soon. Leading manufacturers have announced new products based on the U3 platform. Software developers have also shown interest, and users will soon be able to procure U3 smart software.

Why is it needed?

The platform promises to be extremely useful for people who travel frequently and often use shared PCs.

How does it work?

There are two filetypes associated with the U3 platform. *.u3i is an XML-based text file that defines the application's version, download path and working parameters, and *.u3p is a Zip file containing everything needed to run an application. A 4 MB read-only system partition of the drive pretends to be a CD-ROM drive, while the data partition shows up as a regular Flash drive. Windows is led to believe that the system partition is a CD, so U3 takes advantage of the AutoPlay feature to automatically run the LaunchPad and unlock the data partition.

statement made by both Microsoft and Yahoo!, we're inclined to give them the benefit of the doubt and wait and watch.

Whether or not you will be able to join Yahoo!-style chat rooms and conferences from within MSN Messenger is still not known, but we have a feeling most IM users will be quite satisfied to get simple text IM and online/offline statuses across the competing IM clients for now.

Tell us about your thoughts on the subject—write in to editor@thinkdigit.com.

SOUND DECISIONS

Bose Announces New Products

Bose Corp. announced the launch of new products in the home theatre segment—the Personal Music Centre II, BoseLink AL8, Lifestyle RoomMate and CineMate that eliminate the extra equipment and complexity usually associated with other speakers. Noteworthy among these were the incorporated technologies—'Adapt IQ'—an audio calibration system, 'uMusic'—an intelligent playback system, and the 'Bose link'—one that can expand the aural experience to 14 rooms.

The new Bose CineMate digital home theatre speaker system is designed to enhance the sound of televisions—users will now be able to add the home theatre sound to their TV and DVD players. The CineMate speaker system delivers the performance benefits of a five-speaker system: two angled ported-enclosure speaker arrays work in tandem with TrueSpace surround digital processing circuitry and the hideaway Acoustimass module to produce a broad, spacious home theatre experience without the need for rear or centre channel speakers.

The Bose Lifestyle system expansion was facilitated with the 2005 introduction of Bose link, a seamless, wired connection method. However, the Bose link AL8 homewide wireless audio link enables customers to enjoy the Lifestyle system in areas outside the main room sans any room-to-room wires.

The uMusic intelligent playback system digitally stores an entire music collection and serves as your personal DJ—it evaluates the user's listening preferences and prioritises the music collection automatically, without any charts, menus or manual intervention in terms of creating and managing playlists. The uMusic system stores and organises the content of hundreds of CDs.

Bose prices their products in India slightly

higher than overseas, as India is a high-import duty country.

NOTEBOOKS AND DESKTOPS

NEC Joins The Indian IT Gravy Train

NEC, Japan's largest PC manufacturer, has made its entry into the Indian PC market. This is in a bid to break into the top five PC brands in the country by 2008. NEC Versa notebooks, and PowerMate desktops will be distributed in the country by Enkay technologies. In addition to these, NEC has also launched a plasma TV.

Though the computer major has entered the market much later than its global competitors such as Dell and HP, NEC believes that the Indian computer market is large enough, and that it is growing at a rate that will support large volumes.

The price range for the Versa notebooks would be between Rs 45,000 and Rs 1,40,00. The desktops, priced between Rs 33,000 and Rs 70,000, would include a revolutionary water cooling system. The water-cooling technology built into the PC enables the system to operate in an extremely silent mode of less than 30 decibels.

Mr Wu Teng Guo, Managing Director, Sales, NEC, Asia Pacific, stated that NEC's India entry would be purely through the reseller channel. The company also ruled out the setting up of any assembling or manufacturing units in India in the foreseeable future.

Quizzed about NEC's alignment with either the Blu-Ray or HD-DVD camp, Guo said that they would let the consumer decide. ■

Compiled by Preethi Chamikutty, Mithun Kidambi, Ram Mohan Rao and Renuka Rane

